



What types of indicators should be included in deliverables (e.g. outputs or KPI) lists?

Deliverables lists set out what an organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative should deliver. These are used in performance management, delegation, and contracting. They have names such as outputs lists, statements of service performance, deliverables lists, and Key Performance Indicators (KPIs).

This Types of Indicators Deliverables Lists Should Include Checklist (D8) shows what belongs in a deliverables list. In those instances where you are trying to contract for outcomes, there can be considerable confusion about what should be included in such lists. The traditional accounting-based approach has been for a deliverables list only to include outputs. Outputs are goods or services produced by an agency, provider, policy or initiative which are controllable by the initiative and therefore the mere measurement of them occurring proves that it was the initiative that made them happen (that is, they are 'attributable' to the initiative).

Deliverables lists are only as powerful as the indicators within them that are being used to measure whether the deliverables have been delivered. If you are doing traditional contracting (Types 1 - 3 in the Types of Contracting for Outcomes or Outputs (E3)) you will want your deliverables list to only contain controllable indicators. Given that the deliverables list is for accountability, only including controllable indicators means there can be no argument about whether or not the organization, provider, policy or initiative has made the deliverables happen.

However, in an outcomes-focused world, there is increasing pressure for deliverables lists to include elements more to the right (outcomes) end of the relevant DoView strategy/outcomes diagram than to the left (more likely to be outputs). For the sake of clarity about accountability, it is best to avoid unconsidered 'non-controllables creep'. This is where your deliverables list ends up including more and more not-necessarily controllable indicators (outcomes). This weakens the power of the list as a direct delegation or contracting accountability mechanism. The initiative can simply argue that it did not achieve one or more deliverable because it was outside of its control. If you want to do outcomes-only contracting then you should set it up transparently and formally by using Type 4 from the Four Types of Contracting for Outcomes or Outputs (E3) and avoid 'non-controllables creep' occurring in contracting or delegation.